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**SEEKING JUSTICE** Family members of late sarpanch Santosh Deshmukh meet CM Fadnavis in Mumbai, Jan. 7

## THE CRISIS

- **Aide of NCP minister Dhananjay Munde linked to murder and extortion, sparking resignation calls**
- **Vanjari-Maratha rivalry deepens political tensions in Beed in the Marathwada region**
- **Allegations strain the ruling alliance's unity, just over a month after a decisive poll win**
- **BJP MLA Dhas—leading the charge against Munde—is being propped up by the party to emerge as a Maratha leader in Marathwada, say observers**

ally in BJP MLC Chitra Wagh, who has come out in her support after Munde's loyalists targeted her. Opposition parties have joined the chorus, with an all-party delegation led by former Rajya Sabha MP and Kolhapur royal family scion Yuvraj Sambhajiraje Chhatrapati meeting Governor C.P. Radhakrishnan. Rival NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) MLA Sandeep Kshirsagar from Beed alleges political shielding, claiming Karad's initial omission from the murder case due to Munde's ministerial position. Even Munde's party colleague Prakash Solanke, another MLA from Beed, has called for his head. Dhas tells INDIA TODAY that he's satisfied with police action, but adds: "I'm firm on my demand for Munde's resignation."

A BJP leader says the clash stems from Dhas and Munde's rivalry for political dominance in Beed, and did not represent the official position of their parties. "Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and deputy CM and NCP president Ajit Pawar have said strict action must be taken against the guilty...there is no turbulence in the Mahayuti," he adds. However, NCP youth wing president and spokesperson Suraj Chavan says while his party has always sought exemplary punishment for grave crimes, Dhas also needed to hold the home department accountable. Since CM Fadnavis holds the portfolio, that suggests a willingness among Mahayuti partners to trade edgewise barbs.



**"THREE AGENCIES ARE LOOKING INTO THE CASE, AND MUNDE IS OPEN TO OTHER AGENCIES PROBING THE MATTER TOO. IF ANYONE IS GUILTY, THEY WILL BE PENALISED"**

**AJIT PAWAR**
*NCP chief and deputy CM, Maharashtra*

Ajit, meanwhile, has also found space to defend the man at the centre of the spiralling row. "Munde has clearly said that he does not even have a remote connection with the crime... now, three agencies (a special investigation team, the CID and judicial inquiry) are looking into it, and he is open to other agencies probing the matter too.... If anyone is guilty, they will be penalised," he told reporters. The overwhelming support of OBC communities for the BJP and the Mahayuti in the assembly polls also makes it difficult for the NCP leadership to give Munde the marching orders.

As a political analyst from the Marathwada region says, a case of organised crime has taken on caste colours. While Dhas is a Maratha as was Deshmukh, all accused belong to the powerful Vanjari community, an OBC group to which Munde too belongs. So the Dhas-Munde rivalry reflects the larger Vanjari-Maratha power struggle in Beed and some other parts of Marathwada that goes beyond party affiliations. Maratha leader